the British state was involved in Operation Gulmarg comes from a rather unusual chain of events. In Bannu, which was a district of the northern frontier of India, the Political Agent in August 1947 was Arthur Dredge. Dredge worked very closely with the Brigade Commander of the Indian Army's Bannu Brigade, Brig. C. P. Murray. On 19 August 1947, Murray was at Mir Ali Mirali, which is a frontier settlement 41 km away from Bannu. Dredge was the only British officer at work, that day in Bannu. Murray was visiting Mir Ali Mirali to review the troops of the 1/8 Punjab Regiment. This battalion had arrived from Bannu in February 1947 to relieve the 14/9 Jat Regiment; it was commanded by Lt. Col. L. J. E. Kealey.

The Plucky Major Kalkat

A Sikh officer, Maj. Onkar Singh Kalkat, was in charge of the brigade in the absence of Brig. Murray. Both Murray and Kalkat were essentially waiting to hand over the charge of the brigade to Brig. Mian 'Ganga' Hayauddin (4/12 Frontier Force Regiment) and Maj. Muhammad Hayat respectively. On 20 August 1947, a courier arrived carrying a demi-official letter from Gen. Sir Frank Messervy at General Headquarters in Rawalpindi. As he was authorised to do so, Maj. Kalkat opened the letter. Attached to the letter was an appendix entitled, 'Operation Gulmarg—The Plan for the Invasion and Capture of Kashmir'. The day for the commencement of the operation was 20 October 1947.

At first, Maj. Kalkat thought of speaking about the contents of the letter with Dredge, but then decided against it. The troubled Kalkat called up Murray and related his startling discovery. Murray reached Bannu the very next day, on 21 August 1947, and was also very disturbed after reading the letter. Murray realised that Kalkat's life would be in danger if people came to know that he knew about the contents of the Messervy letter. Murray ordered Kalkat to act normally and wait for the handing over to take place on 5 September 1947. Meanwhile, through a network of Muslim friends, which included the District Commissioner of Mian Wali district, Kalkat